Safeguarding in Athletics

Module 2 – Responding to Abuse and Good Practice

In this module, we will cover:

- how to deal with possible signs of abuse
- barriers to recognising and reporting abuse
- scenarios for reflective thinking
- how to respond if a child confides in you or if you have concerns about a child, young person or adult's welfare
- reporting abuse
- good practice.

Dealing with possible signs of abuse

If you have concerns about a child or adult's wellbeing, the greatest danger is that you do nothing. Countless inquiries have shown that people suspected abuse was taking place, but they weren't quite sure or were worried about getting it wrong.

You may personally know the person who may be involved and feel shock and disbelief that they could be responsible. There are also powerful emotional blocks that can prevent people from even considering the possibility that someone is being abused, so it is important that you force yourself to think of it in the first place.

To do nothing if you have concerns is not an option because it means that you are not fulfilling your duty of care.

It is not your responsibility to investigate; in fact, you must not investigate but you do have an obligation to pass on disclosures, allegations or your concerns to the appropriate person so that they can act to protect a child or adult, if necessary.

UK Athletics (UKA) has 'Safeguarding Children' and 'Safeguarding Adults' policies, as well as established reporting procedures and referral forms. These and other key policies are available on the UKA website.

Barriers to recognising and reporting abuse

Whilst many people may think it is easy to spot a child who is being abused and report it immediately, to others the situation is more complex and there can be a number of reasons for missing the crucial signs.

For example:

A coach or sports leader may fear creating a fuss, getting it wrong or spoiling the relationship they have built with the child's or young person's parents or other coaches.

People may also confuse the signs of abuse or put them down to something else. They may focus on one aspect of a person's training or make assumptions about their wellbeing and not see the bigger picture, or it may come down to plain 'just not noticing' it.

People often express incredulity, particularly if they know and like the alleged abuser.

When it comes to reporting concerns of abuse, there may also be a number of barriers and they are understandable.

They may fear the consequences, both if they are right to be concerned, and also if they are wrong.
You need to be alert at all times to the fact that abuse can, and does happen, and wherever you work or volunteer, remember your focus should be on the person. Their safety, health and wellbeing have to be your primary concern.

Other barriers

In addition to adults facing barriers to recognising and reporting abuse, children and young people who are experiencing abuse also face barriers to disclosing it to those who might help them.

For example:

They may feel ashamed about their situation or concerned that the abuser will get into trouble or go to prison. They may love or care for the abuser and see talking about it as a betrayal. Or, they may fear they may never see their coach or training group again and be worried about the consequences for their club.

They may not even recognise that they are being abused because their circumstances may have become the norm for them.

Caring, considerate adults who take the time to really listen and understand the subtleties of what is being said can provide an opportunity for people to 'open up' and get help.

How to respond if someone confides abuse to you

If a child, young person or adult tells you that they are being abused, it is important that you know how to respond. Here are the universal principles regardless of the age of the person.

- Be welcoming, even if the time isn't convenient for you. It may have taken a great deal of courage for them to approach you and they may not do so again.
- Find a quiet place where your conversation won't be interrupted. However, keep in mind your organisation's guidelines about being alone with an athlete.
- Stay calm and listen very carefully.
- Allow them to tell you at their own pace.
- Ask questions for clarification only.
- Communicate in a way that is appropriate to the person's age, preferred communication method (for example, Makaton or sign language) and ability to understand English.
- Reassure them. Tell them you are sorry this has happened to them and that you will do all you can to help them. Explain what may happen next.
- If emergency help is required, don't delay getting it (police or ambulance).
- Make notes as soon as possible afterwards.
- Contact your club's Welfare Officer immediately.
- The club Welfare Officer should then refer it to the UK Athletics Safeguarding Lead Officer.

What to avoid:

- Do not allow your shock, surprise, anger, distaste, dismay or any other negative emotions to show, although it is OK to show that you're sorry that this has happened to them and empathise.

- Do not make any comments about the abuser or try to guess who they are. If the person discloses the identity of the abuser, speak to your club's Welfare Officer immediately.
- Do not ask leading questions, although you can ask questions to clear up an ambiguity (following a referral, it is a safeguarding professional's role to investigate and you could compromise any subsequent investigations).
- Do not promise to keep the conversation a secret. You will need to share it with your club's Welfare Officer.

If someone wants to talk to you but says that they will do so only if you promise not to tell anyone else; you cannot agree unconditionally. If they or anyone else is being harmed or is likely to be harmed you have a duty to share your concerns.

If they ask for confidentiality and are told this cannot be guaranteed, and as a result they refuse to say anything further, make an immediate report to your club's Welfare Officer.

If your club's Welfare Officer is unavailable, contact the national UK Athletics Safeguarding Lead Officer.

Reporting abuse

Where there are concerns about a child, young person or adult, you should contact your club's Welfare Officer or local authority children's social care department and share your concerns with them and in all cases report your concerns to the person responsible for safeguarding in UK Athletics.

Also contact the UKA Safeguarding Lead if there are allegations about a colleague or you have an allegation made against you.

Reporting procedures

Any person with information of a disclosure, allegation or concern about the welfare of a child must immediately report this in one of the following ways.

If you are part of an affiliated club, you should immediately inform the club's designated Club Welfare Officer who will refer the matter to UK Athletics Safeguarding Lead Officer.

If you work in schools in England or Wales as part of a school club link, school curriculum or on an extra-curricular basis, you should inform the headteacher or the Local Authority Designated Officer(LADO) who can be contacted via Children's Social Care who will follow their normal procedures. In Scotland, Local Authority procedures will be applicable.

If you are working in a local authority facility, you should inform the LA Sports Development Officer or the manager of the facility or the LADO who will follow LSCB or Local Authority procedures.

In any other situation or if the designated person is not available, if the concern is about that person or no action is taken, you should contact the UK Athletics Safeguarding Lead Officer.

If the UK Athletics Safeguarding Lead Officer is unavailable, you should take responsibility and seek advice from either the NSPCC helpline (0808 800 5000), Children 1st (0141 418 5674) in Scotland, the duty officer at local children's services' department or the local police child protection unit. Telephone numbers are in the local telephone directory and should be in your club welfare policy.

Good practice

Good practice means:

- Being open and conducting all interactions with children in a public place and with appropriate consent.
- Avoiding situations where you are alone with one child.
- If you have to meet or coach one child, ensure it is conducted in an open environment and where full consent and emergency contact details have been provided.
- In extenuating and emergency circumstances, if you have to travel alone with a child; gain appropriate consent, avoid consistently having one child alone with you in the car and never share a room on your own with a child.
- Challenging bullying, harassment, foul or provocative language or controlling behaviour that could upset individuals or reduce them to tears.
- Never ignoring bullying by parents, coaches or children. Listening to and supporting the person being bullied.
- Maintaining an appropriate relationship with children; this means treating people fairly, with respect and avoiding favouritism.
- Being friendly and open and ensuring that relationships are appropriate for someone in a position of power and trust.
- Respecting all athletes and helping them to take responsibility for their own development and decision making.
- Avoiding unnecessary physical contact. In certain circumstances physical contact is perfectly acceptable and appropriate, as long as it is not intrusive or disturbing to the athlete and that consent for contact has been given by the individual and appropriate parental consent.
- Being qualified and insured for the activities you are coaching and ensuring that your licence remains valid. Ensure that your practice is appropriate for the age and development stage of each athlete.
- Adopting good practice not only ensures the individual's welfare, it also protects you from possible wrongful allegations. Children very rarely make false allegations. If they do it is usually because they are confused or covering up for someone else's behaviour and hoping their action might scare the real abuser into stopping.

Poor Practice

The following are examples of poor practice and should be avoided.

- Engaging in rough, physical or sexually provocative games, including horseplay.
- A coach shouting comments at athletes when they are not working hard enough.
- A coach using harassing and discriminatory language such as 'you run like a girl'.

- A coach engaging in an intimate relationship with his/her athletes.

- A group of athletes ganging up on a new athlete and refusing to talk to him/her.

- A coach taking a group of children away to a weekend event on his/her own.

The list is not exhaustive and many other examples exist. If any of the following incidents should occur, you should report them immediately to another colleague, make a written note of the event and inform parents and/or appropriate adults of the incident and inform your club's Welfare Officer.

- If you accidentally hurt a child athlete.
- If a child appears distressed in any manner.
- If a child appears to be sexually aroused by your actions.
- If a child misunderstands or misinterprets something you have done.

In summary

In this module we have looked at dealing with possible signs of abuse and the barriers to recognising and reporting abuse. We covered how to respond if someone confides abuse to you and how to report abuse and allegations of abuse. Finally, we looked at examples of good and poor practice.

This concludes your course on 'Safeguarding in Athletics' and we trust you have found it useful. You are now ready to complete the second questionnaire.